

EYES ON TRAFFIC A Rajasthan police drone monitors vehicles on a stretch of Delhi-Jaipur highway

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

▶ RAJASTHAN

'Go Slow, Black Spot in 500 m'

Your Maps app may soon be forewarning you, as Jaipur Range police roll out an accident reduction protocol

cameras to relay emergencies as well as to track number-plates, after zeroing in on speeding, wrong parking, lane violations and drunken driving. Drones fly overhead for overall surveillance.

A second leg of the experiment is more ambitious: pinpointing where fatalities are most likely. Along the 180-km corridor, police have identified 39 black spots using three years of data. Five are in Category A, with over 20 deaths in each—together, they accounted for 140 deaths between 2023 and 2025. Fourteen Category B locations, with 11 to 20 fatalities each, saw 190 deaths. Twenty Category C locations, with six to 10 fatalities, made for 154 deaths. In all, the 39 locations accounted for 484 deaths in three years.

All this feeds a larger mapping programme. Across the eight districts of the range, police have identified 101 accident-prone locations using data from 2023-25. Geospatially mapped, their coordinates have been shared with Google and integrated into Maps. The idea is to arrive at a preventive use of technology: a motorist approaching a perilous stretch being forewarned by Google Maps. A road sign can be missed, particularly at night or at high speed. But a navigation alert can give a driver several minutes to get vigilant and drive safe. The real test will come after this feature comes into wide use.

The urgent need for system repair is obvious. The CAG's latest performance audit of Rajasthan's road safety system showed the usual pile-up of multiple systemic failures crashing into each other at black spots. Not very accidental, that. Of 425 PWD roads examined, only 32 had undergone the full three-stage safety audit covering design, construction and completion between 2018-19 and 2024-25; some 146 roads, costing over Rs 10 crore, got none at any stage. Of 1,175 roads of five kilometres or more constructed by PWD and NHAI, only 636 had undergone even a design-stage audit. Physical inspections found deficiencies in signs and crash barriers. Result: fatalities rose from 10,510 in 2015 to 11,790 in 2024, despite a stated plan to halve deaths. There isn't even one reliable measure: police data captures only cases where an FIR has been registered.

Union minister Nitin Gadkari had come to inspect the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway in July after a crash near Dausa that killed eight and injured 28. The Delhi-Lalsot section recorded 33 accidents and 35 deaths in 2025, followed by 24 accidents and 26 deaths in the first half of 2026. Total fatalities since its 2023 opening: about 200. NH-48 suggests a way forward. ■

Takeaways

- **A lane-driving protocol on NH-48 yields nearly a hundred less accidents, saves 55 lives**
- **Model for Indian highways as drones, CCTV, apps help patrol squads enforce rules**
- **101 'black spots' identified across eight districts and uploaded into Google Maps**